

What else to watch: *Possessed* (1947) ■ *Stage Fright* (1950) ■ *To Live* (1952) ■ *The Hidden Fortress* (1958) ■ *The Outrage* (1964) ■ *Red Beard* (1965) ■ *Samurai Rebellion* (1967) ■ *Ran* (1985) ■ *The Usual Suspects* (1995) ■ *Fight Club* (1999)



Honma) shows up and channels the spirit of the dead samurai, who gives his version of events. Finally, the woodcutter relates what he saw. Each of the stories is radically different, and in its own way entirely self-serving. The bandit asserts that he killed the samurai in a heroic battle; the woman claims not to recall the moment, but suggests that she stabbed her husband on seeing his expression after the rape; the samurai claims to have killed himself; and the woodcutter says that

he observed a fight between the bandit and the samurai, but that it was a messy scrap between two physical cowards.

On the surface, *Rashomon* is a whodunit: it sets up a mystery, introduces the suspects, presents

Tajomaru describes the fight between himself and the samurai as a heroic struggle between two master swordsmen. The woodcutter saw it as a brawl between two terrified men.

the evidence, and asks the audience to draw its own conclusions. But there's a problem. Kurosawa is more interested in the elusive nature of truth than he is in capturing it—he refuses to provide the audience with a definitive account of what happened in the glade.

Shot in an unfussy, austere style, *Rashomon* relies on subtle symbolic imagery to communicate its ideas about memory and truth. The curtain of rain, tinted black by Kurosawa so that it would show up »



The movie established Kurosawa as an internationally renowned filmmaker. It also made a star of Toshiro Mifune (the bandit), with whom Kurosawa would make 16 movies between 1948 and 1964.